

Far-Right Speeches and Emotional Contagion in Parliament

Sequential and Multimodal Evidence from Germany

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The Question and the Existing Answer

Does far-right parliamentary success make democratic debate more negative?

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Valentim & Widmann (2023)

- AfD entry into German state parliaments
- Established parties **do not** imitate far-right negativity
- Instead: **more positive** emotional language
- Interpretation: rhetorical distancing from a norm-breaking actor

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But this is an average, entry-level, text-based result

- Aggregates across speeches and time
- Cannot reveal *immediate* reactions within debates
- Cannot capture *how* responses are delivered

What the Average Misses

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The Sequential Dimension

Parliamentary debate is *ordered*: speeches respond to prior speeches within agenda items.

- What happens immediately following a far-right speech?
- **Expected:** anger ↑, positive emotional language ↓; even if the aggregate is positive

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The Multimodal Dimension

Speech is not only text: legislators communicate through pitch, head movement, and gestures.

- Do responses become vocally and visually activated?
- Are these channels coupled, or do they move independently?
- **Expected**: text follows text, pitch follows pitch, visuals follow visuals

Research Design and Case Selection

Research design



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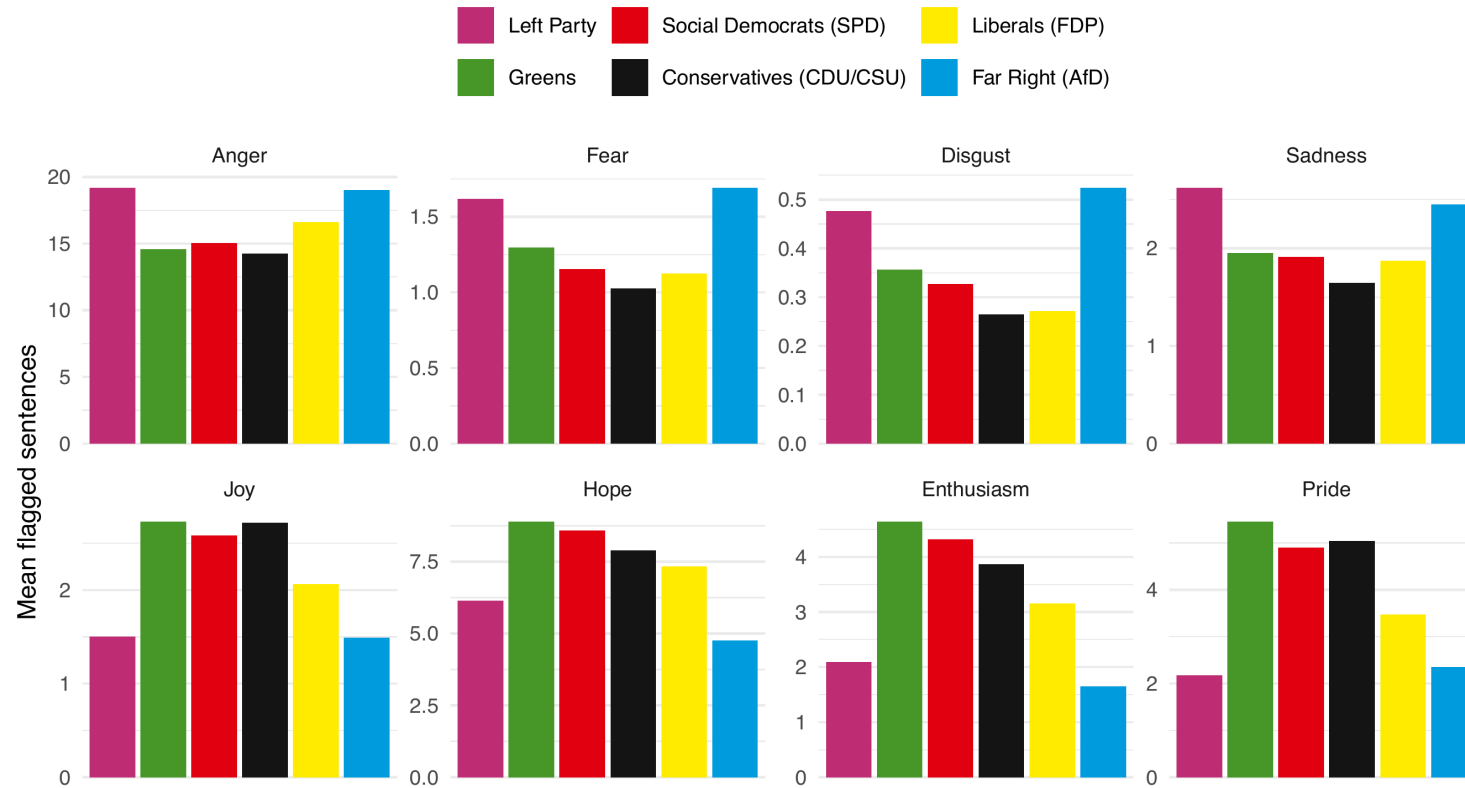
Case Selection

49,662 speeches in ~15,000 hours of video:

Parliament	Period	AfD entered parliament in
Hesse	2013–2025	2018
Saxony-Anhalt	2021–2025	2016
Saxony	2019–2025	2014
Baden-Württemberg	2011–2025	2016
Bundestag	2017–2025	2017

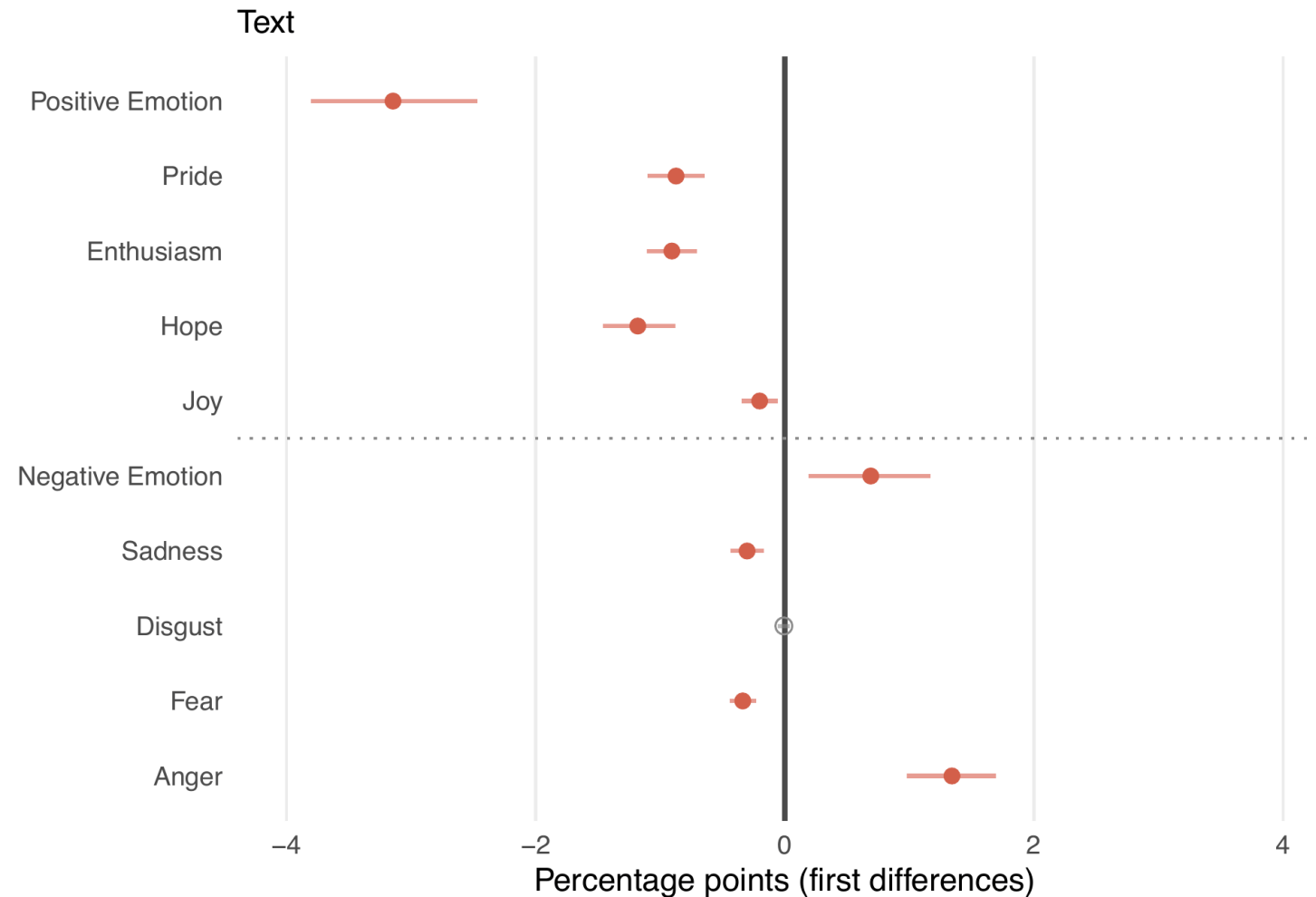
Average Distancing

H1: Non-AfD parties respond to AfD presence with more positive language (replication)

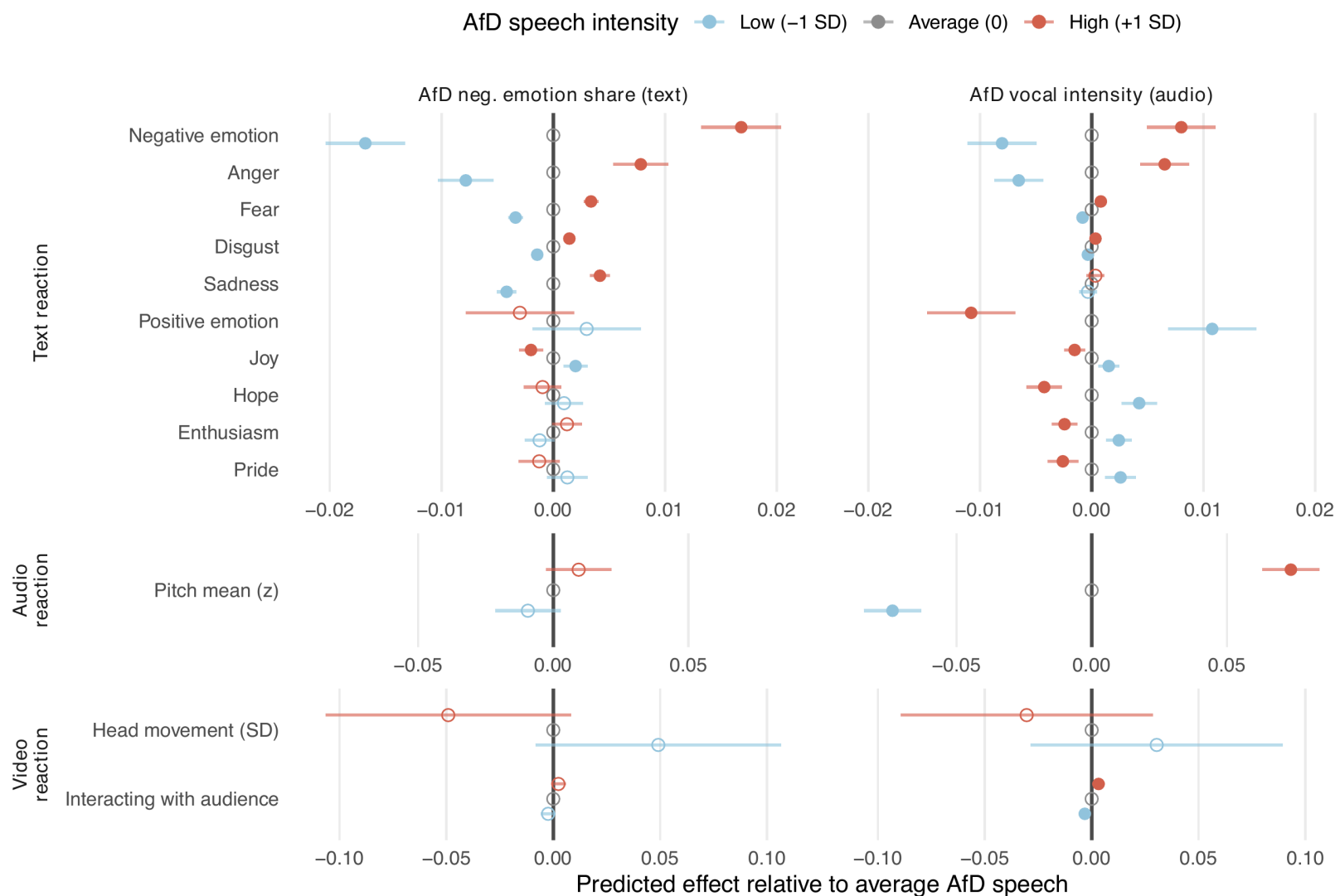


Average vs. Sequential Mirroring

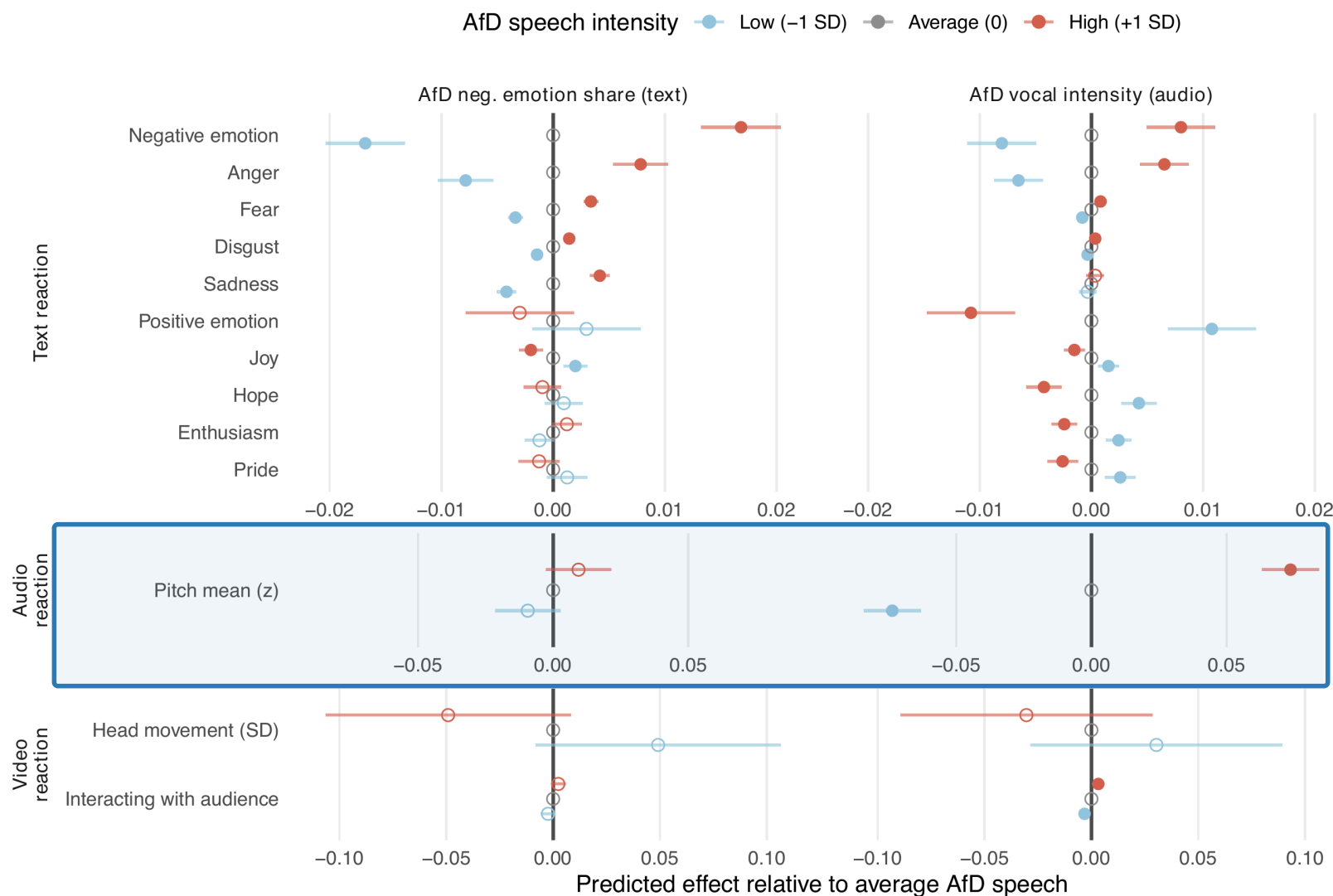
H2: Speeches *after* AfD interventions contain more anger and less positive language



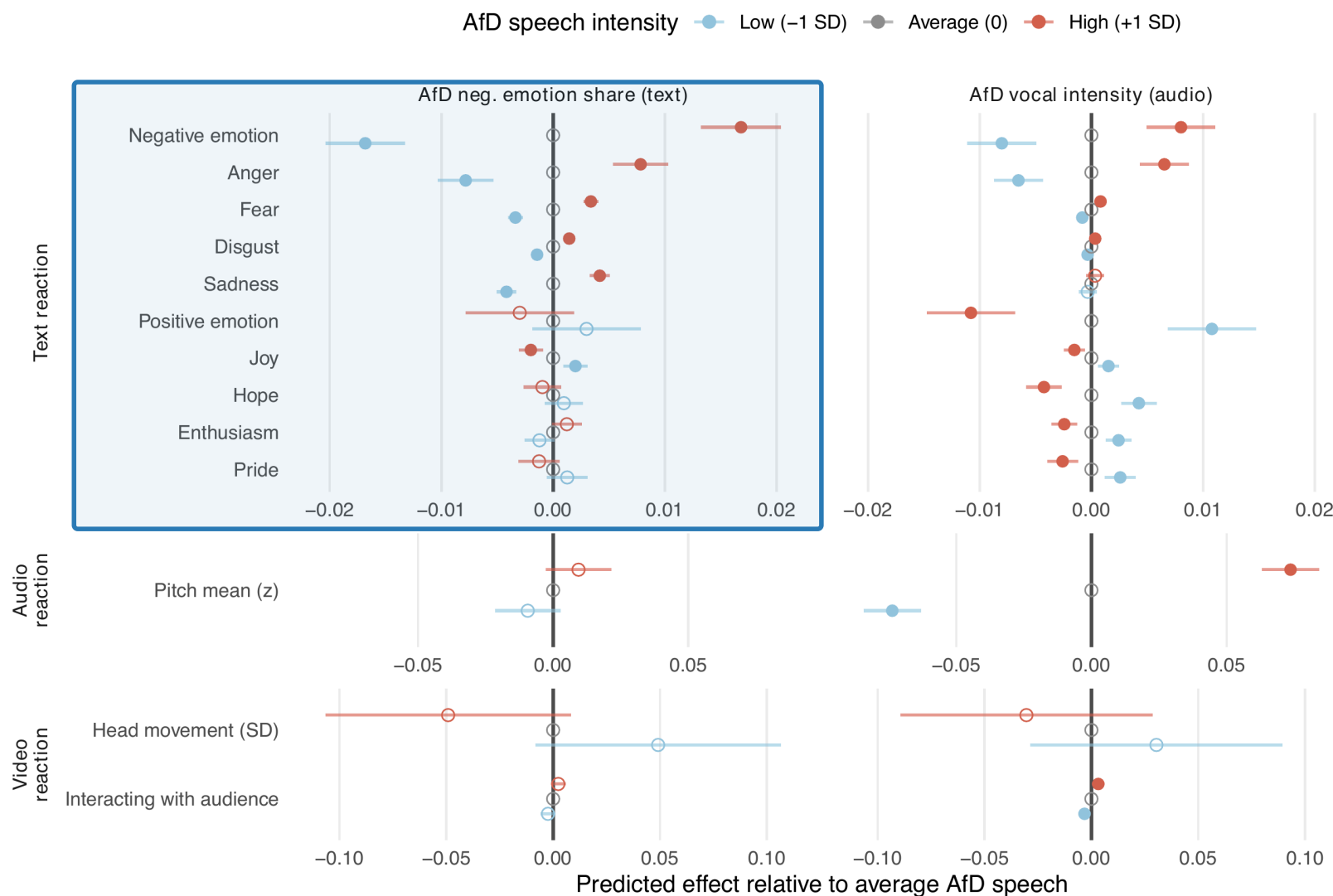
Modality- and Emotion-Specific Transmission



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H3: Modality-specific transmission

- Vocal far-right intensity → pitch elevation in mainstream audio
- Negative emotions in far-right text → more negative emotions in mainstream text

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H4a/b: Emotion-specific coupling

- Far-right anger → pitch elevation in mainstream audio (H4a)
- Negative → negative; positive → positive (H4b)

Takeaways & Next Steps

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- Causal identification:** DiD using the pre-AfD-entry period as control; shifts in the post-AfD window vs. baseline behaviour

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Christian Arnold · **Andreas Kuepfer** · Christian Stecker

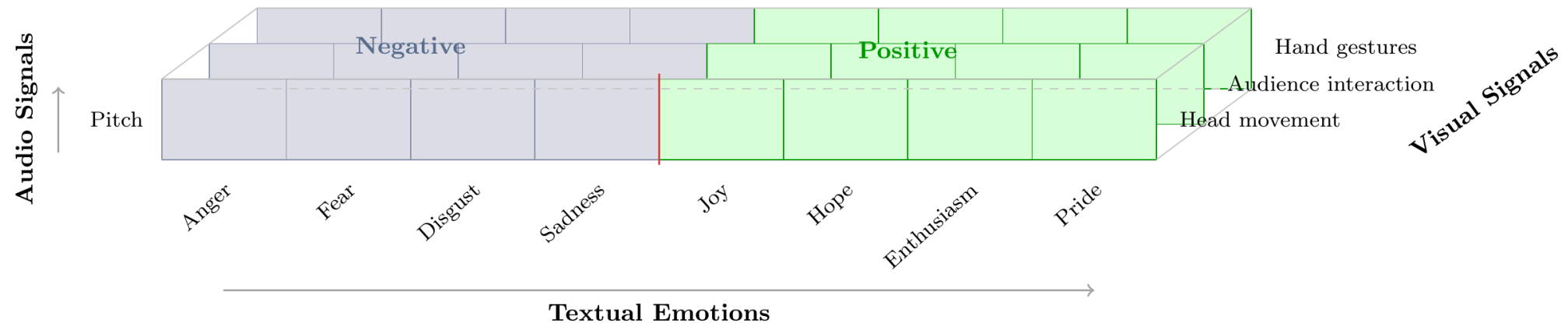
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Measurement Framework

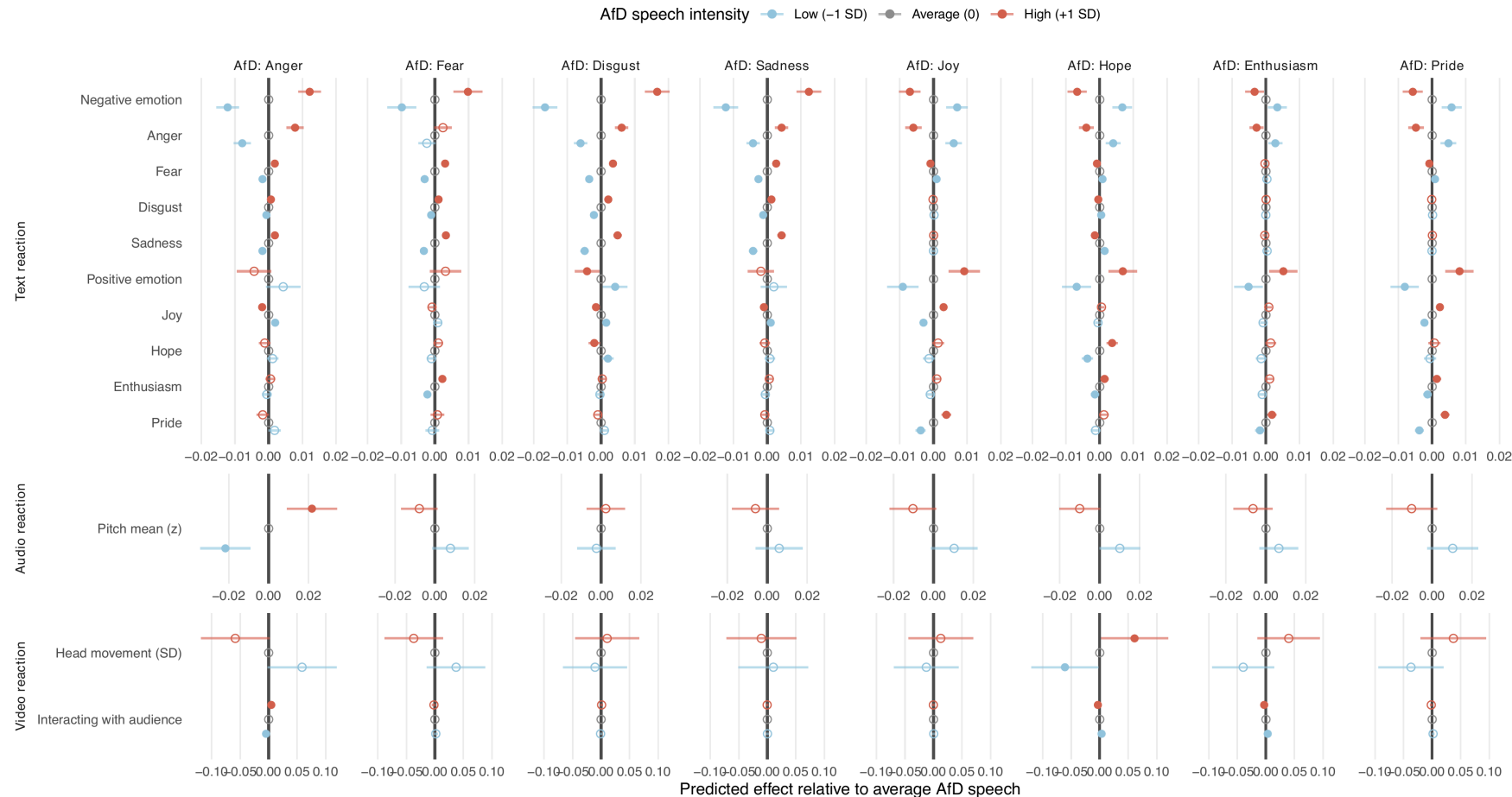
Three dimensions:

- **Text** (8 discrete emotions: anger, fear, disgust, sadness; joy, hope, enthusiasm, pride)
- **Audio** (vocal pitch)
- **Visual** (head movement, audience interaction, hand gestures)



Emotion-Specific Coupling

H4a Increased far right anger → pitch elevation; **H4b** Negative (positive) emotions transmit Negative (positive) responses



Average vs. Sequential Mirroring (descriptive)

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